SciencesPo

Année universitaire 2026/2027
Collège universitaire / Campus de Nancy
Semestre d'automne

Comparative Politics Discussion Section

Lea Dornacher • Noémie Piolat

DISCUSSION SECTIONS
Wednesdays, 13:15–15:15 or 15:30–17:30

TEACHING ASSISTANTS
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Objectives

The discussion section serves three objectives: first, a space for you to reflect on and expand upon the lecture material through assigned readings; second, a practicum on research design and the comparative method; and third, a workshop for the research paper.

Structure of Course and Requirements

You will meet with your teaching assistant for two hours each week, after the lecture. Some sections are devoted entirely to questions of research design and methods, while others focus on the discussion of assigned readings and the methodologies used therein.

Learning takes time and effort. Passing off other people's work as your own (including uncritically copying and pasting output from generative AI tools such as ChatGPT) is the academic equivalent of **stealing**, and will **not be tolerated**. Any instance of plagiarism or cheating will result in an immediate 0 for the assignment in question and will be reported, which could lead to removal from the program.

If we have any doubt about whether a piece of work (including your research paper) was genuinely written by you, we reserve the right to schedule a short oral defense, in which you will be asked to explain and justify your arguments, choices, and sources. This is not a punitive measure in itself, but a way of verifying authorship when questions arise.

If you are ever unsure whether something crosses the line, ask us first.

Assigned Reading

Most sessions have one or several assigned readings. Please complete the readings before class and come prepared to discuss them.

Presentations

Each reading is presented by a team of two students.

Presentations are evaluated across five broad dimensions: the general presentation of the article,

including the clarity of its context and research question; the methodology, covering both the correct identification of the research design (cases, data, variables) and the clarity of its explanation; the findings, assessing the accurate presentation of results and the presenters' understanding of how those findings connect to the article's conclusions; critical analysis and discussion, which considers the presentation's connection to broader course themes and the quality of the discussion question posed to the class; and clarity and orality, encompassing structure, time management, and the overall quality of delivery and visual support.

Participation

You are expected to participate in the discussion of the readings each week. The best way to do this is to take notes on the reading and come prepared to offer comments and react to your colleagues' comments.

Research Paper Workshops

Three discussion sections are devoted to workshopping your research paper. The guidelines for the paper can be found on Moodle. During these workshops, you are expected to come prepared and to participate in the activities developed by your teaching assistant; even when there is no assigned reading, you may occasionally be asked to prepare something in advance (for example, a potential research question for your term paper).

Discussion Section Evaluation

Your overall final grade for this course is composed of three equal parts: the written exam (1/3), the research paper (1/3), and the discussion section (⅓), as indicated in the syllabus of the Lecture. The research paper is graded as its own component and is separate from your discussion section grade.

Your discussion section grade (1/3 of your final grade) is made up of the following:

Assignment	Weight
Outline for research paper	**Pass or Fail**
Presentation of readings in class	**90%**
Participation	**10%**

Note: because the discussion section is itself worth 1/3 of your final grade, participation represents approximately 3.3% of your overall final grade.

Plan for Discussion Sections

Date	Session	Topic

09/09/2026	Session 1	Course Introduction
16/09/2026	Session 2	Methods and Research Designs in Comparative Politics
23/09/2026	Session 3	Methods: Regression
30/09/2026	Session 4	Most Similar and Most Different Design, Research Question
07/10/2026	Session 5	Workshop on Research Questions and Literature Review
14/10/2026	Session 6	Research Questions, Case Selection, and Data
21/10/2026	Session 7	Workshop on Methods and Data
28/10/2026	—	*Fall Break — no class*
01/11/2026	—	***Deadline: research proposals***
05/11/2026	Session 8	Final Paper Workshop
11/11/2026	—	*No class — Armistice Day*
18/11/2026	Session 9	Academic Writing
25/11/2026	Session 10	Reading Presentation and Discussion
29/11/2026	—	**Deadline: final paper**
02/12/2026	Session 11	Content Revision / Semester Recap
09/12/2026	Session 12	Exam Preparation

09/09/2026 Session 1 — Course Introduction

This introductory session lays the groundwork for the course. After covering logistics, we turn to the basic goals of comparison (description, classification, hypothesis testing, and prediction) before introducing the core vocabulary of political science research: cases, units and levels of analysis, theory, concepts, measurement, and causality. We then situate these tools within broader debates about ontology, epistemology, and methodology, and contrast deductive and inductive reasoning and counterfactual thinking as ways of building and testing arguments.

MANDATORY CONCEPTUAL READINGS

- Landman, T., & Carvalho, E. (2013). *Issues and Methods in Comparative Politics: An Introduction* (4th ed.), Chs. 1–2: "Why compare countries?" and "How to compare countries." Routledge.
- Abbott, A. (2004). Explanation. In *Methods of Discovery: Heuristics for the Social Sciences* (Contemporary Societies series). W. W. Norton.

16/09/2026 Session 2 — Methods and Research Designs in Comparative Politics

Building on the first session, we examine the major epistemological and methodological divides that structure the discipline: rationalist versus interpretivist epistemologies, and behavioralist versus institutionalist approaches. We revisit deductive and inductive reasoning and counterfactual thinking in more depth before previewing the qualitative comparative research designs developed further in later sessions.

MANDATORY CONCEPTUAL READINGS

- Jennings, W., & Turnbull-Dugarte, S. J. Politics as behavior. In C. Hay (Ed.), *What Is Politics?*
- Abbott, A. (2004). Basic debates and methodological practices. In *Methods of Discovery: Heuristics*

for the Social Sciences (Contemporary Societies series). W. W. Norton.

23/09/2026 Session 3 — Methods: Regression

This session introduces the basics of quantitative research (including large-N versus small-N designs and an introduction to descriptive statistics) and the building blocks of regression analysis. We start with the distinction between dependent and independent variables and the steps of conceptualization, operationalization, quantification, and measurement, along with the related standards of validity and reliability. We then turn to ordinary least squares (OLS) regression and practice reading and interpreting regression tables.

MANDATORY CONCEPTUAL READINGS

- Landman, T., & Carvalho, E. (2013). *Issues and Methods in Comparative Politics: An Introduction* (4th ed.), Ch. 3: "Comparing many countries." Routledge.
- Lowndes, V., Marsh, D., & Stoker, G. (2017). Quantitative methods (Ch. 15). In *Theory and Methods in Political Science*. Bloomsbury Publishing.

30/09/2026 Session 4 — Most Similar and Most Different Design, Research Question

This session introduces the most similar and most different systems designs as tools for qualitative comparison, drawing the logical bridge to large-N research and to the counterfactual reasoning discussed earlier in the course. We close by discussing how to identify a research puzzle and formulate it as a research question (what distinguishes a good research question from a poor one, the main types of research questions, how a question shapes research design, and what is expected of the question you develop for your own paper).

MANDATORY READINGS (2 PRESENTATIONS)

- Faucher, F., & Hay, C. (2015). Voting rituals in France and the United Kingdom. *Revue française de science politique, 65*, 213–236. https://doi.org/10.3917/rfsp.652.0213
- Zollinger, D. (2024). Cleavage identities in voters' own words: Harnessing open-ended survey responses. *American Journal of Political Science, 68*(1), 139–159. https://doi-org.scpo.idm.oclc.org/10.1111/ajps.12743

CONCEPTUAL READING

- Lowndes, V., Marsh, D., & Stoker, G. (2017). The comparative method (Ch. 16). In *Theory and Methods in Political Science*. Bloomsbury Publishing.

07/10/2026 Session 5 — Workshop on Research Questions and Literature Review

This workshop session begins with a debrief of the exercise on puzzling and formulating research questions. We then turn to the literature review: how to reference sources correctly, with a short introduction to Zotero; how to find the right sources through library search tools and Google Scholar; and how to structure a review that synthesizes rather than merely summarizes the literature, builds an argument, and identifies gaps for critique.

MANDATORY READINGS (2 PRESENTATIONS)

- Abou-Chadi, T., Cohen, D., & Wagner, M. (2022). The centre-right versus the radical right: The role of migration issues and economic grievances. *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies, 48*(2), 366–384. https://doi.org/10.1080/1369183X.2020.1853903
- Jan, M. (2026). Between goals and means: The electoral consequences of parties' climate proposals. *West European Politics*. Advance online publication. https://doi.org/10.1080/01402382.2026.2674875

CONCEPTUAL READINGS

- Knopf, J. W. (2006). Doing a literature review. *PS: Political Science and Politics, 39*(1), 127–132.
- Halperin, S., & Heath, O. (2025). *Political Research: Methods and Practical Skills* (4th ed., pp. 102–108). Oxford University Press.

14/10/2026 Session 6 — Case Selection and Data

The session covers case selection with an eye to your research paper, and closes with a discussion of methods for gathering and analyzing data.

MANDATORY READINGS (2 PRESENTATIONS)

- Bolet, D. (2021). Drinking alone: Local socio-cultural degradation and radical right support—the case of British pub closures. *Comparative Political Studies*. Advance online publication. https://doi.org/10.1177/0010414021997158
- Bellè, E., & Faury, F. (2025). Going local, going mainstream? Ethnographic study of two French cities governed by the Rassemblement National. *Government and Opposition, 60*(1), 125–140. https://doi.org/10.1017/gov.2024.4

CONCEPTUAL READING

- Seawright, J., & Gerring, J. (2008). Case selection techniques in case study research: A menu of qualitative and quantitative options. *Political Research Quarterly, 61*(2), 294–308.

21/10/2026 Session 7 — Workshop on Methods and Data

This workshop is devoted to a Q&A on methods, giving you the chance to raise questions about the methods you already know and to discuss the methods you intend to use for your own research paper.

MANDATORY READING (1 PRESENTATION)

- O'Grady, T. (2019). Careerists versus coal-miners: Welfare reforms and the substantive representation of social groups in the British Labour Party. *Comparative Political Studies, 52*(4), 544–578. https://doi.org/10.1177/0010414018784065

CONCEPTUAL READING

- Lowndes, V., Marsh, D., & Stoker, G. (2017). Qualitative methods (Ch. 15). In *Theory and Methods in Political Science*. Bloomsbury Publishing.

28/10/2026 — Fall Break

01/11/2026 — Deadline: Research Proposals

05/11/2026 Session 8 — Final Paper Workshop

This session is devoted to workshopping your final research paper.

No mandatory reading.

11/11/2026 — No class — Armistice Day

18/11/2026 Session 9 — Academic Writing

This session focuses on academic writing skills relevant to your research paper: how to express doubt and confidence in your claims, how to cite sources correctly, useful phrases for scholarly writing, and how to structure your argument for clarity.

MANDATORY READING (1 PRESENTATION)

- Thürk, M., & Klüver, H. (2025). Hitting the sweet spot? The electoral consequences of supporting minority governments. *Comparative Political Studies, 58*(8), 1670–1698. https://doi.org/10.1177/00104140241271210

25/11/2026 Session 10 — Reading Presentation and Discussion

This session is devoted to the presentation and discussion of the assigned reading below.

MANDATORY READING (1 PRESENTATION)

- Yordanova, N., Ershova, A., Khokhlova, A., Obaid Ul-Islam, S., & Glavaš, G. (2025). When the EU Council responds to public opinion: Negotiating European policy integration. *European Union Politics, 26*(3), 453–476. https://doi.org/10.1177/14651165251340212

02/12/2026 Session 11 — Content Revision

MANDATORY READINGS (2 PRESENTATIONS)

- Sczepanski, R. (2024). Who are the cosmopolitans? How perceived social sorting and social identities relate to European and national identities. *Comparative Political Studies, 57*(7), 1210–1239.

09/12/2026 Session 12 — Exam Preparation

This final session is dedicated to exam preparation: reviewing methods concepts, discussing time management, and going over general strategies for approaching the exam.

MANDATORY READING (1 PRESENTATION)

- Lutz, P. (2021). Reassessing the gap-hypothesis: Tough talk and weak action in migration policy? *Party Politics, 27*(1), 174–186. https://doi.org/10.1177/1354068819840776

CONCEPTUAL READING SUGGESTION

- Hacker, J. S., & Pierson, P. (2014). After the 'master theory': Downs, Schattschneider, and the rebirth of policy-focused analysis. *Perspectives on Politics, 12*(3), 643–662. https://doi.org/10.1017/S1537592714001637
- March, J. G., & Olsen, J. P. (2008). Elaborating the 'new institutionalism.' In S. A. Binder, R. A. W. Rhodes, & B. A. Rockman (Eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Political Institutions*. Oxford University Press. https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780199548460.003.0001